

Course Dates: September 24, 2025 - December 3, 2025

Class Times: Wednesday evenings, 6:00-9:30pm

Location: PACCAR 290

Professor: Michael Megalli

Office Hours: By appointment over Zoom (Email to schedule)

Contact Information: mmegalli@uw.edu

1. COURSE OVERVIEW

The term 'entrepreneurial marketing' was first used in 1982 at an American Marketing Association conference. The concept combined two previously distinct disciplines to help companies improve their marketing in a competitive environment.

Today, 45 years later, entrepreneurial marketing has taken on a plethora of new meanings, including marketing for smaller companies and game changing products. So, what really is entrepreneurial marketing? Is it just marketing for startups? Is it marketing on a shoestring budget? Or is it marketing in creative, new ways? What differentiates entrepreneurial marketing from other types of marketing? Throughout the term, this course will cover all of the interrelated aspects of entrepreneurial marketing and explore its real-world applications.

Ultimately, this is a course about change. It's about how change happens and why—or when—it doesn't. And how change itself is changing in a world that appears to be changing faster than ever.

Entrepreneurship is the practice of making innovative change happen in the world. Change provides entrepreneurs with a critical context for new ideas—and change is also the output of any successful new venture. Entrepreneurs are agents of change, who are themselves highly aware of and attuned to shifts, disruptions, and transitions in culture and values; broader changes that create conditions in which new opportunities for innovation may be hidden in plain sight.

Innovation requires more than just new ideas or inventions—it requires customers. Marketing is the process of creating a customer—not just by selling a value proposition, but by having a deep enough understanding of the customer's needs and preferences that they can be met with high-value combinations of tangible and intangible products, services, technologies, and relationships. Customers cannot be compelled; they must be won over.

2. COURSE DESIGN

The intent of this course is to steep students into the world of start-ups, innovation, and entrepreneurial marketing. Students will be introduced to what it takes to be successful in marketing and bringing new products and services to market. We'll do this through a combination of readings, case studies, market observation, analysis, and independent study.

This 10-week course is organized into two distinct parts. The first half will focus on strategic marketing topics such as consumer discovery, value propositions, and business models. The second half will focus on tactics, different GTM methods in driving sales and reinforcing positioning and brand preference. Practical application will be reinforced through in-class discussions with your peers, opportunities to workshop case studies facilitated by the professor, and your final project. We will also hear from guest speakers in order to gain insights into the day-to-day start-up experience from practitioners.

Each week students will think deeply about customers, innovation, and marketing by reading the works of key thinkers, and then enable students to practice applying concepts in real-world situations.

The course encourages students to use the marketing and entrepreneurial frameworks and principles learned throughout their Foster career. Students will also have an opportunity to evaluate all aspects of marketing and make cogent recommendations to strengthen the customer, brand, and business growth for a start-up of their choice.

Weekly student journals will hone students' alertness to entrepreneurial marketing in the wild, in both business and non-business contexts while applying the weekly readings. Cultivating the habit of alertness is an important trait of an entrepreneurial mindset.

In the final project, you'll get to dive deeper by profiling an entrepreneurial company and build your own case study, assessing their company, business model, value proposition, product line, positioning, target audience, channel, and marketing execution. The process of 'reverse engineering' in this way will build students' understanding of how such a venture is structured and maintained.

September 24 – October 22nd Marketing Strategies During the first four weeks, we'll focus on the concepts underlying marketing and new value creation efforts. We'll read the foundational works about marketing and entrepreneurship and apply them to observation and analysis of entrepreneurship you see in the market.	October 29th—November 19th Marketing Tactics In the second half of the course, our focus will switch to the more tactical aspects of entrepreneurial marketing. How does the practice of marketing work? What activities does it entail and what tools does it use? How does it change as it moves from addressing new value creation to growth stages of the business?
December 3th Final projects The last week will be reserved for group project presentations.	

Learning objectives

The main objectives of this course are to improve your ability to:

1. Identify and describe the challenges and opportunities of marketing for entrepreneurial organizations.
2. Assess, identify opportunities, and make recommendations to improve a start-up's value proposition.
3. Design effective marketing and go-to-market strategies to maximize a start-up's chance of winning in these markets.
4. Effectively identify and recommend the marketing tactics that will best drive key marketing metrics to deliver a start-up's business performance.
5. Communicate and defend your own marketing assessments and recommendations and critically examine and build upon the recommendations of others.

Class structure and assignments

The class is designed so that each week students will think deeply about customers, innovation, and marketing by reading the works of key thinkers, and then enable students to practice applying concepts in real-world situations.

Weekly student journals will hone students' alertness to entrepreneurial marketing in the wild, in both business and non-business contexts while applying the weekly readings. Cultivating the habit of alertness is an important trait of an entrepreneurial mindset.

Each week we will hear from guest speakers—each with a different entrepreneurial and marketing background, all with years of experience putting these ideas into practice in the real world.

In the final project, you'll get to dive deeper by profiling an entrepreneurial company and build your own case study, assessing their company, business model, value proposition, product line, positioning, target audience, channel, and marketing execution. The process of 'reverse engineering' in this way will build students' understanding of how such a venture is structured and maintained.

While it might change a little some weeks, most of the time class will fall into three periods. We will take one short break after the first hour.

- 6:00-7:20** | Lecture
 - Reading discussion
 - Group exercises/breakout discussions
- 7:20-7:30** | Break
- 7:30-8:45** | Guest speaker
- 8:50-9:30** | Discussion and wrap up

Most weeks, we will be joined by an entrepreneur or marketing practitioner who will speak to the class from approximately 7:30-8:30 pm. In addition to providing real world perspectives, this will help to pace and structure our time together in class.

Assignment schedule

Readings	September 24th – November 12 th *
Alertness Journals	October 1st – November 5 th *
Final project, 200-word precis	October 29th
Final project presentations	December 3rd

*Please note: you will not have readings or Journal entries due on October 29th to give time to choose final project subjects.

A note on readings

All of the readings for the class will be available in a Course Pack from the University Bookstore. Please try and buy this pack before the first class. In case you're not able to get it in time, I've included a copy of the first week's readings on Canvas.

We'll be reading a series of foundational texts about both entrepreneurship and marketing. Sometimes the examples used in these articles and books will seem dated. Your challenge will be to see beyond those examples and focus on the wisdom and insights they provide. Throughout the course, we will work on finding contemporary examples that reflect these timeless principles—if you truly understand them, you'll be able to continue applying them long after the course is over.

Alertness Journals

For five weeks—between October 1st to November 5th—you'll document examples that you observe in the world that you feel exemplify the ideas we are discussing. Stay alert and you'll start seeing examples everywhere you look.

I'm open to any technology or format that you choose for your journal, as long as it can include both photos and text. Some options include OneNote, Evernote, Notion, Word/Sheets/Pages, PowerPoint/Slides/Keynote, HTML, PDF, etc.

Please note!

Your journal doesn't have to involve a lot of writing. Pictures, screen shots, recordings of any kinds are all acceptable and maybe even preferable to long writing. Some simple notes should be enough to convey what you found interesting about the thing you're documenting. Why did it get your attention? How did it get your attention? What is it promising? What is it asking of you?

3. COURSE EXPECTATIONS AND POLICIES

This is an advanced course of study. Each week we will cover a broad range of material—in addition to group or individual assignments. Expect the course to be challenging and fast-paced.

Attendance

It is expected that students attend every single synchronous class. Each class will have workshops, exercises, and assignments that are vital to students' grades. If students are not present, their participation for the day will be a zero. Exceptions will only be made for illness or family emergencies. If students are exempt for the two aforementioned exceptions, they will be asked to complete exercises on their own time.

Class Participation

Each student is expected to fully participate in every exercise and workshop. This can look like spoken contributions, discussion with peers, bringing personal examples, and asking questions. If students feel as though they are unable to participate for personal reasons, they must reach out to the professor to arrange an accommodation.

Classroom culture and the use of technology

We all occasionally need to use a phone or look something up while in a class. In fact, it's often useful to look something up that can inform your perspective about a topic we're discussing.

However, there's a difference between that and habitually using technology in ways that are a distraction to you, me and the rest of the class. When we meet in the first class, we'll spend 10 minutes establish ground rules together and then stick to them.

Academic Conduct

Students are expected to adhere to the University of Washington's standard of conduct. According to Section 5.B.1 of [The Student Conduct Code](#), students' responsibilities include:

- Practicing high standards of academic and professional honesty and integrity;
- Refraining from any conduct that would violate the rights, privileges, and property of others;
- Refraining from any conduct that would substantially disrupt or materially interfere with University operations;
- Refraining from any conduct that could reasonably cause harm to or endanger the health, safety, or welfare of other persons; and
- Complying with the rules, regulations, procedures, policies, standards of conduct, and orders of the University and its schools, colleges, departments, units, and programs.

Disability Resources

This course is inclusive and accessible to all students. If you have established accommodations with Disability Resources for Students (DRS), please communicate your approved accommodations to the Instructor at your earliest convenience to review your needs in this course. If you have not yet established services through DRS, but have a temporary health condition or permanent disability that requires accommodations (conditions include but not limited to mental health, attention-related, learning, vision, hearing, physical or health impacts), you are free to contact DRS at 206-543-8924 or uwdrs@uw.edu or disability.uw.edu. DRS offers resources and coordinates reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities and/or temporary health conditions. Reasonable accommodations are established through an interactive process between you, your instructor, and DRS. The University of Washington's policy and practice is to create inclusive and accessible learning environments consistent with federal and state law.

4. STUDENT PERFORMANCE EVALUATION

Your final grades will be calculated based on the total of four inputs: the personal survey, weekly journals, class participation, and the final project. I've included detailed [grading rubrics](#) in this document and on Canvas.

Personal Survey – 5%

The first week of class you will fill out a short survey that will give me a better idea of who's in the class, what your backgrounds are, and what you are most interested in learning. Your answers will have a direct impact on how we approach things, so please make your voice heard! This is worth 5 points—the easiest 5 points on offer all semester.

Alertness Journals – 40%

A big part of the journal grading is that you did it and put some thought into it. Each of the 5 journal entries is worth 5 points based on submitting on time, bringing in interesting examples, and referencing relevant ideas from the week's reading. Mostly I want to see that you're thinking about this stuff and looking for it in everyday life.

Class participation – 15%

This is a grade for in-class participation, preparedness, and good citizenship. I know that some people don't feel comfortable speaking in front of large groups of people, and I know that doing so in front of a large group of your peers can be intimidating. However, this is a substantial part of your grade, so I encourage you to make the effort. If this is a real problem for you, please swing by office hours or find time to meet with me, and we will figure out some accommodation.

Final project – 40%

This is a small group project that will have both a written report and a class presentation. In this project you will create a detailed case study of an entrepreneurial venture or initiative. The case you create should provide a detailed analysis of the venture's marketing, incorporating themes from our readings, discussions and speakers.

Late Work

All work is due at 5:59pm on the day of class. Journals submitted after than time will lose 2 of 8 possible points.

If you have a legitimate reason why you will not be able to submit an assignment on time, please reach out to met via email before class.

5. CLASS SCHEDULE

Week 1: Introduction to Entrepreneurial Marketing—September 24

Explores the definition of entrepreneurial marketing in-depth and the challenges a marketer faces within a start-up environment.

What is entrepreneurship? Economists have struggled to define "entrepreneurship" for more than two hundred years. Because we don't have the luxury of time, we'll start with Peter Drucker. With the publication of his classic, Innovation and Entrepreneurship in 1984, Drucker sought out to present entrepreneurship as a systematic and purposeful practice. We'll use Drucker as the foundation for establishing a frame of reference to which we can refer back throughout the course.

Reading

Entrepreneurship and Innovation, Peter Drucker (pp21-44)

"Systematic Entrepreneurship"

"Purposeful Innovation and the Seven Sources"

Personal Survey

Because of the short week, you won't have a journal entry. Instead, please answer a short survey that will give me a better idea of who's in the class, what your backgrounds are, and what you are most interested in learning. Your answers will have a direct impact on how we approach things, so please make your voice heard! Also this is worth 5 points—the easiest 5 points on offer all semester, so act now!

Please fill out this short survey to give me a better sense of who you are and what you're hoping to get out of the course: <https://form.typeform.com/to/U5xKOiTB>

Week 2: Value Proposition Development—October 1st

Demystifies the critical marketing activities in the early stages of a startup. We will discuss product market fit, consumer discovery, and assess the components of a value proposition.

What is marketing, really? Say "marketing" to most people and they instinctively think of advertising and communications of one kind or another. This is natural—we all live in a world where we're bombarded by messaging all day, every day for most of our lives. But marketing is about more than just communications and sales. At its core, marketing is the central function of any business—and particularly an entrepreneurial business.

To establish a clear framework for understanding the function of marketing, we'll turn this week to Theodore Levitt. Writing more than 50 years ago, Levitt left a rich legacy

of powerful marketing ideas. And while we live with marketing as a constant feature of our lives, these core concepts are as relevant today as they were when they were first published.

Reading

The Marketing Imagination, Theodore Levitt ("Differentiation—of Anything" pp72-93, "Marketing Intangible Products and Product Intangibles" pp 94-110, "The Marketing Imagination pp 127-140)

OPTIONAL:

"Marketing Myopia", Theodore Levitt (<https://store.hbr.org/product/marketing-myopia-hbr-bestseller/R0407L>)

Journal prompt

Please see Canvas for this week's Alertness Journal prompt.

Week 3: Customer Adoption and Diffusion—October 8th

Explores the way that natural diffusion curve of disruptive innovation and the influence of segments of customers on adoption.

How do ideas spread and businesses grow? Like other entities, businesses grow in stages. Diffusion theory is the study of this growth, and it was made famous by Geoffrey Moore, whose book *Crossing the Chasm* helped tech companies to understand how to navigate each of these stages of growth, including the dreaded "chasm" between early adoption and the early majority. Understanding these phases of adoption is key for understanding how entrepreneurial ventures either grow or remain niche players.

Reading

Crossing the Chasm, Geoffrey A Moore

"High-Tech Marketing Illusion" pp 11-28

Case studies pp 89-103

"Creating the Competition" pp 164-171

Journal prompt

Please see Canvas for this week's Alertness Journal prompt.

Week 4: Unpacking Innovation—October 15th

Explores different types of innovation in order to better understand the sources of innovation and opportunities for innovation.

What are the different types of innovation and stages of innovation?

We've talked about how entrepreneurs innovate to create new kinds of value for new kinds of customers, but this innovation can take many forms—from game-changing to experience-enhancing. Clayton Christensen was a leading thinker about disruptive innovation and how this kind of innovation fundamentally differed from other types of innovation in its form and impact. This week we'll focus on different type of innovation to get a better understanding of how they determine the strategic approaches of different entrepreneurial ventures.

Reading

["What is Disruptive Innovation?"](#), Clayton Christensen

Entrepreneurship and Innovation, Peter Drucker ("Principles of Innovation" pp133-140)

Journal prompt

Please see Canvas for this week's Alertness Journal prompt.

Week 5: Positioning and Differentiation—October 22nd

Explores the psychology of human perception and decision making, as well as strategies for how to competitively position products, services, and companies.

Positioning and differentiation

Human beings make meaning and order out of the world as a means of survival. The marketer's primary challenge is to get ahead of the ways that this interpretation happens to claim a space or "position" within the mind of the customer or prospective customer. This space is always claimed relative to the spaces that are already owned by competitors or alternatives sources of value. The key is understanding how communications, experiences and designs can be used to set an offering apart—effectively differentiating it from these alternatives.

Reading

[Positioning, the Battle for your Mind](#), Al Ries and Jack Trout (pp1-69 and 201-210)

Chapter 1 (What Positioning is All about) to Chapter 8 (Repositioning the Competition)

Chapter 25 (Playing the Positioning Game)

[Crossing the Chasm](#), Geoffrey A Moore ("Positioning" pp 177-190)

***Final project preparation** In preparation for your final projects, we'll spend 10 minutes at the end of class today talking through final projects and fielding any questions that you have as you get ready to submit your case selections next week.

Week 6: Measurement and Budgets October 29th

Explores key measurements of the success of entrepreneurial tactics and initiatives as well as setting budgets to reflect key business priorities.

How do entrepreneurial marketers fund and evaluate their initiatives?

This week we will begin to make the shift from strategy to tactical considerations in entrepreneurial marketing. In order to implement any strategy, it is necessary to understand the metrics and size of budget you will need to work within. So how do start-ups determine metrics and budgets? What marketing metrics do start-ups typically use? As an entrepreneur, how do you determine how much the budget should be? How should you allocate dollars allocated across the marketing funnel? And importantly, how does budget influence strategies and tactics and vice versa?

In class, we will define and sort through marketing tactics up and down the marketing funnel, working within the confines of a constrained marketing budget. What's the difference between owned, earned, and paid media, and which ones are most important to building a brand, acquiring a customer base, and driving sales?

Please note: there will be no readings or journal entries this week as you'll begin preparing for your final projects by selecting a enterprise for your case study analysis.

Final Project Preparation—selecting a case study

Please see Canvas for details about selecting your partner and case study

Week 7: Customer Insights—November 5th

Businesses have access to more data than ever about customers, and yet it feels harder than ever to really know what it is that customers are looking for and how these needs/wants can be met by new products and services. Part of the challenge is that we're trained to think in terms of value propositions which are inevitably focused on what companies make as opposed to the diverse things that customers really need and want. To be effective for driving both innovation and marketing, we need insights that take a more expansive view of the people we're trying to reach.

Reading

[Why Qualitative Market Research Belongs in Your Startup Toolkit](#), Jesse Caesar

"Know your Customers' 'Jobs to be Done'" Clayton Christensen

Journal prompt (final week of journals)

Please see Canvas for this week's Alertness Journal prompt.

Week 8: Experimentation, Learning, and Agility—November 12th

Marketing technology—experimentation, learning, and agility

In a digital world, with an ever-expanding set of powerful marketing tools, the role of marketing has taken on many of the characteristics of software development. This has made the marketer's job more technical than ever before and has also opened up opportunities to experiment and validate before committing valuable time and resources to actually building new marketing programs. To better understand this challenge and opportunity, we'll read relevant parts of Eric Ries' classic, *The Lean Startup* as well as Scott Brinker's underground classic, *Hacking Marketing*, to understand the marketing in a digital age.

Reading

The Lean Startup, Eric Ries ("Learn" pp 37-55, "Grow" pp206-223)

Hacking Marketing, Scott Brinker (pp 9-46, pp 207-219)

Review: Chiefmartec.com's 2020 [MarTec 5000](#)

Week 9: The Role of Brand—November 19th

Brand mechanics / Why brands work

Brands are a force-multiplier. This week, we talk about how brands work, how they're built and how they build momentum for entrepreneurial organizations.

There are no readings this week, as you'll be busy working on your final projects, but bring 3 examples of brands that resonate for you to class. Please don't bring in the obvious—no Apple, Nike, Starbucks, etc.

Week—November 26th

Since this is the night before Thanksgiving, we will not have class.

Week 10—December 3rd

Final project presentations

We will dedicate this class to team presentations of final projects. Depending on how many teams we end up having, we'll figure out a maximum amount of time for final presentations.

Grading Rubrics

Alertness Journals – 40%

A big part of the journal grading is that you did it and put some thought into it. Each of the 5 journal entries is worth 8 points (a total of 40 points) based on submitting on time, bringing in interesting examples, and referencing relevant ideas from the week's reading. Mostly I want to see that you're thinking about this stuff and looking for it in everyday life.

Journal entry is completed on time	2 pt Full marks Journals are submitted at 6pm on the day of class	0.0 pts No points Journals are not submitted at 6pm on the day of class
Journal entry reflects an alert and creative attention to the market	3 pts Full marks Interesting, original, and creative ideas, backed up with insights about what makes the ideas strong.	0.0 pts No points Ideas are not interesting, original, or creative, and/or are not backed up with insights about what makes the ideas strong.
Journal entry reflect a clear understanding of readings and themes	3 pts Full marks Journal entry and observations are supported with specific and relevant ideas from this week's reading.	0.0 pts No points Journal entry and observations are not supported with specific and relevant ideas from this week's reading.

Class participation – 15%

This is a grade for in-class participation, preparedness, and good citizenship. I know that some people don't feel comfortable speaking in front of large groups of people, and I know that doing so in front of a large virtual group can be intimidated. However, this is a substantial part of your grade, so I encourage you to make the effort. If this is a real problem for you, please swing by office hours or find time to meet with me, and we will figure out some accommodation.

Quality of in class contribution (80% weight)	12 pts Excellent Contributions in class reflect exceptional preparation. Ideas offered are always substantive and provide one or	9 pts Good Contributions in class reflect thorough preparation. Ideas offered are usually substantive; provide good	6 pts Satisfactory Contributions in class reflect adequate preparation. Ideas offered are sometimes substantive,	2 pts Needs Improvement Contributions in class reflect inadequate preparation. Ideas offered are seldom
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	more major insights as well as providing a fruitful direction for the class. If this person were not a member of the class, the quality of the discussions would be diminished significantly.	insights and sometimes a fruitful direction for class discussion. If this person were not a member of the class, the quality of discussions would be diminished considerably.	provide generally useful insights, but seldom offer a major new direction for the discussion.	substantive, provide few useful insights, and rarely offer a constructive direction for the class. Class contributions are few and far between. Multiple instances when not prepared during classroom discussions, activities, team project work, and/or random calling.
Good citizenship (20% weight)	3 pts Excellent Treats students, instructor, and guest speakers with dignity and respect. Active listener. Appropriate use of technology during class time. Arrives to class on time.	2 pts Good Overall good citizenship, but one instance when not showing respectful behavior or staying on task.	1 pts Satisfactory Two instances when not showing respectful behavior or staying on task.	0 pts Needs Improvement Three or more instances when not showing respectful behavior or staying on task.

Final project – 40%

This is an individual project to do an analysis of an entrepreneurial venture's marketing and to incorporate themes from our readings, discussions, and speakers. This is a great opportunity to apply what we're learning by observing it in the real world.

Quality of insight and analysis (50% weight)	20 pts Excellent A thorough 360-degree analysis of the company's marketing program with a detailed explanation of how the program works across the customer experience. Clear insights into the strategy driving the tactical execution.	16 pts Good A thorough 360-degree analysis of the company's marketing program with a good explanation of how the program works across the customer experience. Some insight into the	12 pts Satisfactory An analysis of the company's marketing program how the program works across parts of the customer experience. Limited insight into strategy driving tactical execution.	8 pts Needs Improvement A basic description of the company's marketing program. Limited insight into strategy driving tactical execution. Unpersuasive POV on what is effective/ineffective
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	Very persuasive POV on what is effective/ineffective about the approach.	strategy driving the tactical execution. Persuasive POV on what is effective/ ineffective about the approach.	Somewhat persuasive POV on what is effective/ ineffective about the approach.	about the approach.
Reference to course subject matter and readings (40% weight)	15.0 pts Excellent Presentation demonstrates a solid and insightful mastery of the ideas and concepts covered through Week 5 of the course. You effectively reference specific readings and in-class discussions in supporting your analysis.	12.0 pts Good Presentation demonstrates an understanding of ideas and concepts covered through Week 5 of the course. You reference some readings and in-class discussions in supporting your analysis.	9.0 pts Satisfactory Presentation demonstrates familiarity with some ideas and concepts covered through Week 5 of the course. Limited reference to readings and in-class discussions in supporting your analysis.	6.0 pts Needs Improvement Presentation makes superficial use of ideas and concepts covered in the course and limited reference to readings and in-class discussions in supporting your analysis.
Quality of written presentation (10% weight)	5.0 pts Excellent Comprehensively documented visual "tour" of the marketing program's component parts across all relevant media and channels. Presentation is clear, creative, and engaging in how it documents the program.	4.0 pts Good Well-documented visual "tour" of the marketing program's component parts across most relevant media and channels. Presentation is clear in how it documents the program.	3.0 pts Satisfactory Partial "tour" of the marketing program's component parts including some relevant media and channels. Presentation is relatively clear.	1.0 pts Needs Improvement Incomplete or unclear "tour" of the marketing program's component parts including some media and channels.